Royal Proclamation of 1763

King George III · October 7, 1763

Source: U.S. National Archives; Avalon Project (Yale Law School), avalon.law.yale.edu/18th_century/proc1763.asp

Issued by King George III at the end of the French and Indian War (Seven Years' War), the Proclamation reserved land west of the Appalachian Mountains for Native nations and forbade colonial settlement there. To the British government it was a cost-saving, stability-protecting measure. To many colonists — especially land speculators and frontier settlers — it was an unwelcome restriction on the very lands they thought they had fought to win, and it became one of the earliest grievances driving colonial resistance.

Connect: British 'salutary neglect' before 1754 shaped colonial expectations. What changed after the war ended?

Key Passages

On Native lands

> And whereas it is just and reasonable, and essential to Our Interest and the Security of Our Colonies, that the several Nations or Tribes of Indians, with whom We are connected, and who live under Our Protection, should not be molested or disturbed in the Possession of such Parts of Our Dominions and Territories as, not having been ceded to, or purchased by Us, are reserved to them, or any of them, as their Hunting Grounds.

On the proclamation line

> We do therefore … strictly forbid, on Pain of Our Displeasure, all Our loving Subjects from making any Purchases or Settlements whatever, or taking Possession of any of the Lands above reserved, without Our especial Leave and Licence for that Purpose first obtained.

On settlers already west of the line

> And We do further strictly enjoin and require all Persons whatever, who have either wilfully or inadvertently seated themselves upon any Lands … to remove themselves from such Settlements.

HAPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HAPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Context *What was happening when this was written?*	The French and Indian War (1754-63) had just ended; Britain gained land to the Appalachians and beyond, faced Pontiac's Rebellion, and carried a large war debt.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	British colonists and colonial governors (especially land speculators and frontier settlers), and the Native nations living west of the Appalachians.
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	King George III and the British government, focused on imperial order and the cost of defending the frontier, not on the colonists' hopes for western land.

HAPP Element	Your Analysis
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ practice (A·C·E): Identify ONE way the Proclamation contributed to colonial discontent.

2. What does the language about 'Our loving Subjects' suggest about the Crown's view of the colonists?

3. Which colonial groups would have been most angered by the Proclamation? Why?